



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course guide fall 2025

SK2211, The Performance of Democracies

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1. Introduction

This course explores factors that explain cross country variation in democratic performance and their implications. More specifically, it is concerned with how variation in factors such as institutions, norms and values are related to outcomes in general dimensions of performance, such as, human well-being, corruption and sound management of public finances, among others. It therefore focuses less on issues that have to do with what democracy is, democratic transitions or democratic survival and rather with why and how democracies ‘succeed or fail’ in the aforementioned areas. It also reviews the implications that follow for citizen attitudes and democratic support.

2. Learning outcomes

At the end of the course the students are expected to be able to:

- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of the dimensions in institutional variation among democracies and how these are related to performance.
- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of implications of democracies' performance for individual-level attitudes and regime support.
- Identify the key strands in the relevant literature and organise its findings in a meaningful manner.
- Review and compare empirical findings from diverse sets of academic literature
- Critically appraise findings and identify contradictions or lacunae.
- Independently use existing theories to analyse cases.
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique and use of references.
- Independently plan and propose a minor research project that answers questions pertaining to the course content.
- Systematize and integrate, as well as critically assess, different theories about the determinants of performance in democracies.

3. Organisation of the course

The course consists of lectures, seminars, presentations, individual tutorials and two written assignments.

Lectures address explanations for the variation in the Performance of Democracies across countries. We focus on macro explanations, micro factors and the course as well as history and current developments.

Seminars take place in groups. Each seminar group will have one tutor for the duration of the course. Groups are formed after the course administration has the complete list of participants. There are five seminars in total. The first seminar is an introductory seminar where students are given information on how seminars are conducted, the course assignments (presentations, memo, and the final paper) the overall organization of the course and administrative issues. Further queries from students are settled during this seminar as well.

The following seminars are discussions based on the assigned readings for each lecture (listed below). The structure and format of the seminars will be discussed during the skills seminar. Students are required to read all readings as both seminar discussions and written assignments require in depth knowledge and critical assessment of the literature provided. **The attendance of the seminars 2-4 are compulsory. Those who missed a seminar have to present a summary of the literature of the seminar they missed (1,500 words). The compensatory work is to be uploaded into the relevant folder on CANVAS and emailed to their seminar tutor. Seminar 5 is designed to help students to develop their final papers.**

In each seminar, groups of two to three students (depending on class numbers) will provide an overview of the literature that is discussed and set the tone for the seminar discussion to follow. These presentations should focus on the story that comes out from the readings included in that seminar and present it coherently. Presenters should not provide small summaries of each paper but provide an overview in the form of a short literature review. The

presentation should include questions that remain, issues that should be discussed and suggestions for further research. The groups will be put together by the course coordinators once participation is finalized. Some flexibility will be provided to accommodate schedules or availability but by and large students will be expected to follow the structure provided.

Before seminar 5, students should upload on CANVAS a synopsis (abstract) of their final paper (200 words max), presenting an under-researched issue in the relevant literature, major limitation(s) of the existing literature and how they think of moving the literature forward. During the seminar, each student presents her/his idea for the final paper and receives feedback from other students and the seminar tutor.

Individual Tutorials

Students may address their seminar tutors during their designated office hours with specific short queries regarding the content of the three substantive seminars and/or the final paper.

Written Assignments

Student performance is assessed through two written assignments, one seminar presentation, and active participation in seminars. The written assignments are a) a memo focusing on a specific case(s); and b) a final paper in the form of a project proposal.

Please add this information in the header on the first page of your papers.

Last name:

Course:

First name:

Part of Course:

Personal Number:

Grading Teacher:

Written Assignment 1

Briefing Memo (max 2000 words, 12 pt. font, Times New Roman, 1.5 line spacing, consistent referencing style (APA, MLA or Chicago, etc..)) due 1st of October at 17.00)

You will be asked to write a short memo for a deliberative assembly debating the design of the country's amended constitution. You will provide recommendations taking into account features of the country (such as the political culture, the party system, the governance record etc.) on a) executive vs legislature power relations (parliamentarism vs presidentialism, number of cameras, degree of separation of powers) OR b) the electoral system. You will provide recommendations on ONE of these. You can pick one of three countries (the country cases will be announced during the introduction lecture and skills seminar).

The memo should include:

- The evidence from the literature regarding the choices and the pros and cons of different designs (State of the Art)
- The specifics of the country that might justify one or the other arrangement.

- Your own argument based on the above regarding the system that the country should adopt.

Note:

- You do not need to necessarily propose changes to the existing constitution. You may also argue in favour of the status quo

More information and specific instructions regarding the memo will be provided during the skills seminar.

Written Assignment 2

Final Paper (max 4000 words, 12 pt. font, Times New Roman, 1.5 line spacing, consistent referencing style (APA, MLA or Chicago, etc..) due 4th of November at 17.00)

The goal of this assignment is to provide a research proposal for an under researched issue in the performance of democracies literature.

A brief sketch below:

- Based on what you have read pick a subject from institutions, norms, political economy and prepare a research proposal for funding a new research project.
- Present the state of the art (where the research stands as of now) on this issue.
- Identify the missing element in the literature or what is called a ‘gap’
- Provide the main research question to be asked and a theory that supports testable hypotheses.
- Show how the proposed research will address the gap and explain your contribution to the academic literature and potentially policy decisions.

Detailed instructions for the final paper will be provided in writing during the skills seminar.

Grading

The grading scale comprises: Pass with Distinction (VG), Pass (G) and Fail (U). To obtain the grade Pass for the entire course the student must have passed all assignments. To obtain the grade Pass with distinction on the whole course the grade Pass with distinction must have been achieved on the two written assignments.

4. General information

Academic Writing

The three hallmarks of good academic writing are clarity, precision, and intellectual honesty. Unlike some other forms of writing, academic texts should be free from ambiguity, and they should offer the reader plainly stated arguments, not rhetorical tricks. This does not mean that they have to be boring, of course, but it does mean that, whenever there is a conflict between being linguistically elegant and clear, the latter should take precedence. For example, in

academic writing, it might be preferable to consistently use the same terms for the same concepts instead of using synonyms, even though this would be dull in other types of writing (such as fiction). To organize the text, a good rule of thumb is to make one point per paragraph.

Good academic writing is cumulative; it proceeds from, communicates with, and seeks to contribute to previous work on the topic of choice. It is essential that the author (or authors) gives due credit to previous work. There should never be any doubt as to whether segments of text, ideas, claims or results are the author's own or drawn from other sources. To ensure this, academic writing requires a transparent system of citation. Never 'copy and paste' text from other sources without citing those sources and enclosing direct quotes in quotation marks. Copying text without indicating it is a quotation constitutes plagiarism. Use references consistently and accurately. These requirements hold for all academic texts, from short student assignments and course papers to master theses and academic books and journal articles.

On the course pages on canvas there are on line courses on academic integrity that you can take in order to get more information on the above.

5. Schedule

Information about the schedule:

The schedule and additional information are available at the course's CANVAS page. You will be informed about any changes, additions etc on CANVAS, as well as e-mailed to the participants' GU-addresses. In other words, please check your GU e-mail and the CANVAS page during the course. Note that the schedule below can be subject to change due to unforeseen circumstances. Always consult the schedule available on line from CANVAS. Depending on the final students registered for the course we will have 1,2 or 3 seminar groups but the exact number is not yet certain. Changes will only be reflected in the on line schedule.

Day	Time	Teacher	Topic	Room: Consult on-line schedule
The Performance of Democracies				
2024-09-01	13:15 - 15:00	GX, AA	Introduction, skill seminar	
2024-09-04	13:15 - 15:00	FB	Normative Expectations and Democratic Performance	
2024-09-05	10:15 - 12:00	GX	The Performance of Democracies – Introducing the Puzzle	
Political Institutions				
2024-09-10	10:15 - 12:00	GX	Constitutional Design, Electoral Rules and Performance	
2024-09-11	10:15 - 12:00	GX	Electoral Democracy and Corruption	
2024-09-17	10.15- 12.00	GX	Seminar 2 <i>Compulsory</i>	
			Redistribution, Inequality – Vicious vs Virtuous Circles	
2024-09-19	13:15 - 15:00	MN	State Capacity and Democracy	
2024-09-22	13:15 - 15:00	FB	Public Goods Provision, Redistribution and Inequality	
2024-09-23	13:15 - 15:00	FB	Clientelism and vote buying	
2024-09-26	13:15 - 15:00	GX	Seminar 3 <i>Compulsory</i>	

Norms, values, Culture				
2024-10-01	17:00		Submission: memo	
2024-10-02	13:15 - 15:00	AA	Modernization, Value Change and Democratization.	
2024-10-03	13:15 - 15:00	AA	Values, Gender and the Quality of Democracies	
2024-10-08	13:15 - 15:00	AA	Seminar 4 <i>Compulsory</i>	
2024-10-13	17:00		Submission: Synopsis	
2024-10-16	10.15-12 13:15 - 15:00	AA, GX	Seminar 5: Feedback on synopsis for final paper	
2024-11-04	17:00		Submission: Final paper	

6. List of Literature

All readings are available online through the University library

Normative Expectations and Democratic Performance

Canache, Damarys 2012. Citizens' Conceptualizations of Democracy: Structural Complexity, Substantive Content, and Political Significance. *Comparative Political Studies* 45(9) 1132–1158

Crow, D. 2010. The Party's Over: Citizen Conceptions of Democracy and Political Dissatisfaction in Mexico". *Comparative Politics*, 43(1) (October 2010).

Przeworski, A. 2009. Self-Enforcing Democracy. In Donald A. Wittman and Barry R. Weingast (eds) *The Oxford Handbook of Political Economy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press).

Ulbricht, T. (2018). Perceptions and Conceptions of Democracy: Applying Thick Concepts of Democracy to Reassess Desires for Democracy. *Comparative Political Studies*, 51(11), 1387–1440. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414018758751>

The Performance of Democracies – Introducing the Puzzle

Bäck H., & Hadenius, A. (2008). Democracy and state capacity: Exploring a J-Shaped relationship. *Governance* 21 (1): 1–24.

Montinola, G., R., & Jackman, R., W. (2002). Sources of corruption: A cross-country study. *British Journal of Political Science* 32: 147–170.

Holmberg, S. & Rothstein, B. (2011). Correlates of Democracy. Gothenburg: The Quality of Government Institute, University of Gothenburg, Working paper 2011:10

Gerring, J., Knutsen, C. H., & Berge, J. (2022). Does democracy matter?. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 25(1), 357-375.

McMann, K.M., Seim, B., Teorell, J. and Lindberg, S., (2020). Why low levels of democracy promote corruption and high levels diminish it. *Political Research Quarterly*, 73(4): 893-907.

Recommended

Doucouliaos, H., & Ulubasoglu, M.A. (2008). Democracy and economic growth: A metaanalysis. *American Journal of Political Science* 52 (1): 61-83.

Constitutional Design and Electoral Rules

Gerring, J., & Thacker, S. C. (2004). Political institutions and corruption: The role of unitarism and parliamentarism. *British Journal of Political Science*, 34(2): 295-330.

Chang, Eric. & Golden, M. (2007). Electoral systems, district magnitude and corruption. *British Journal of Political Science* 37:115-137.

Kunicová, J. & Rose-Ackerman, S. (2005). Electoral rules and constitutional structures as constraints on corruption.” *British Journal of Political Science* 35 (4): 573-606.

Xezonakis, G., & Dawson, S. (2021). Electoral Rules and Corruption. *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*, p.309.

Dawson, S., Schwenk, J., & Xezonakis, G. (2024). The Distribution of Executive Power and Corruption: A Meta-Analytical Review. *Comparative Political Studies*, 00104140241290213.

Recommended

Oates, W. (1999). An essay on fiscal federalism” *Journal of Economic Literature* 37(3): 1120-1149.

Golden, M & Mahdavi, P. (2015). The institutional of components of political corruption, in: Ed. Ruben Ruiz Rufinio and Jennifer Gandhi (eds) *Handbook of Comparative Political Institutions*. New York: Routledge Press, 2015.

Persson, T., Roland, G. & Tabellini, G. (2003). The economic effects of constitutions. MIT Press (subsection, 2.4 in ch. 2 and whole chapter 4)

Shrestha, K., Martinez-Vazquez, J., & Hankla, C. (2023). Political decentralization and corruption: Exploring the conditional role of parties. *Economics & Politics*, 35(1), 411-439.

Electoral Democracy and Corruption

Anduiza, E., Gallego, A. & Munoz, J. (2013). Turning a Blind Eye: Experimental Evidence of Partisan Bias in Attitudes Toward Corruption. *Comparative Political Studies* 46(12): 1664-1692.

De Vries, C.E. and Solaz, H. (2017). The electoral consequences of corruption. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 20(1):391-408.

Zechmeister, E., & Zizumbo-Colunga, D. (2013). The Varying Political Toll of Concerns about Corruption in Good versus Bad Economic Times. *Comparative Political Studies*. 46(10): 1190-1218

Agerberg, M. (2020). The lesser evil? Corruption voting and the importance of clean alternatives. *Comparative political studies*, 53(2), 253-287.

Ferraz, C. & Finan, F. (2008). Exposing Corrupt Politicians. The Effects of Brazil's Publicly Released Audits on Electoral Outcomes. *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 123(2):703–745.

Recommended

Xezonakis, G., Kosmidis, S. & Dahlberg, S. (2016). Can electors combat corruption? Institutional Arrangements and Citizen Behaviour. *European Journal of Political Research*, 55(1):160-176.

Bågenholm, A., & Charron, N. (2020). Accountable or Untouchable? Electoral accountability in Romanian local elections. *Electoral studies*, 66:102183.

State capacity and democracy

D’Arcy, Michelle and Marina Nistotskaya. 2023. “State Capacity, Quality of Government, Sequencing and Development Outcomes”. In A. Bågenholm, M. Bauhr, M., M. Grimes and B. Rothstein (eds.), *Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 756-780. (Available online through GU library).

D’Arcy Michelle and Marina Nistotskaya. 2017. State First, Then Democracy: Using Cadastral Records to Explain Governmental Performance, *Governance* 30(2): 193-209.

Knutsen, Carl-Henrik. 2013. Democracy, State Capacity, and Economic Growth. *World Development* 43: 1-18

Public good provision, Redistribution and Inequality

Annaka & Higashijima 2021: Political liberalization and human development: Dynamic effects of political regime change on infant mortality across three centuries (1800-2015), *World Development*, Volume 147, 2023

De Kadt, D., & Lieberman, E. (2020). Nuanced Accountability: Voter Responses to Service Delivery in Southern Africa. *British Journal of Political Science*, 50(1), 185-215. doi:10.1017/S0007123417000345

Habyarimana, James, Macartan Humphreys, Daniel N. Posner And Jeremy M. Weinstein (2007). Why Does Ethnic Diversity Undermine Public Goods Provision? *American Political Science Review*, pp 709-725. doi:10.1017/S0003055407070499.

Keefer, P. and Khemani, S. 2005. Democracy, public expenditures, and the poor: understanding political incentives for providing public services. *World Bank Research Observer*, 20 (1): 1–28.

Recommended:

Meltzer, Allan H., and Scott. F. Richard. 1981. “A Rational Theory of the Size of Government.” *Journal of Political Economy* 89: 914–27.

Clientelism and vote buying

Hicken, Allen and Noah L. Nathan (2020). Clientelism's Red Herrings: Dead Ends and New Directions in the Study of Nonprogrammatic Politics. *Annual Review of Political Science* 2020 23:1, 277-294

Nichter, Simeon and Michael Peress 2016. Request Fulfilling: When Citizens Demand Clientelist Benefits. *Comparative Political Studies* 1-32.

Scott, J. (1972). Patron-Client Politics and Political Change in Southeast Asia. *American Political Science Review*, 66(1), 91-113. doi:10.2307/1959280

Stokes, Susan C. 2009. “Political Clientelism.” In Carles Boix & Susan C. Stokes (eds.), *Oxford Handbook of Comparative Politics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press).

Modernization, Value Change and the Quality of Democracies

Welzel, C., & Inglehart, R. (2010). Agency, values, and well-being: A human development model. *Social indicators research*, 97(1), 43-63.

Welzel, C. (2014). Evolution, empowerment and emancipation: How societies climb the freedom ladder. *World Development* 64:33-51

Silva, Manuel Santos, Amy C. Alexander, Stephan Klasen, and Christian Welzel. "The roots of female emancipation: Initializing role of Cool Water." *Journal of Comparative Economics* 51, no. 1 (2023): 133-159.

Gender Equality and the Quality of Democracies

Bohigues, Asbel, Jennifer M. Piscopo, and Amy Alexander. "The foundational effects of gender: Exploring Latin American Elites' perceptions of corruption." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* (2024).

Ottervik, Mattias, and Zheng Su. "Gender system and corruption: Patriarchy as a predictor of "fairness"." *Governance* (2022)

Merkle, Ortrun, and Pui-Hang Wong. "It is all about power: Corruption, patriarchy and the political participation of women." *In Women and sustainable human development: Empowering women in Africa*, pp. 353-368. Cham: Springer International Publishing, 2019.

Mechkova, Valeriya, and Ruth Carlitz. "Gendered accountability: when and why do women's policy priorities get implemented?." *European Political Science Review* 13, no. 1 (2021): 3-21.

Supplementary Reading

Alexander, A. C. Gender, Gender Equality, and Corruption. 2023. In *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Edited by Andreas Bågenholm, Monika Bauhr, Marcia Grimes, and Bo Rothstein. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

7. Additional information on Academic Integrity

Attempts to deceive during examinations

An attempt to deceive during examinations means that a student has attempted to give an impression of their performance in a written exam or some of form of assessment that is not true. That is what is commonly referred to as cheating, or attempting to cheat. There are different kinds of attempts to deceive, such as plagiarism, prohibited aids and prohibited collaboration. Deception can also take other forms.

- **Plagiarism** means that a student has presented someone else's text or other material as if it were their own text or material.
- **Prohibited aid** means that a student has used aids, including AI, that were not permitted according to the instructions.
- **Prohibited collaboration** means that students have collaborated with each other in breach of the instructions.

Plagiarism: Copying material from the Internet, from books, journals, reports, or from a fellow student and then presenting it as one's own is strictly forbidden! Plagiarism is theft of someone else's work and will result in immediate fail of the assignment. Please note that the inclusion of a source in a bibliography list is not in itself sufficient attribution of another's work. In addition, unless it is a proper citation with a reference, any direct copying of text is forbidden. All submitted student work is screened with a program called *Ouriginal*, which compares a student's written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet)

and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique. More information on references and how to avoid plagiarism can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/search-read-write/reference-management-and-plagiarism>

Prohibited aid: All your submitted texts should be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generated by AI. Unless there are specific instructions for the use of AI for an assignment, it should not be used and presented as your own text. The use of any tools to cheat during on campus exams (e.g. DISA) is also strictly forbidden.

Prohibited collaboration: students can discuss their work, but individual submissions must be your own original writing, and hence not too similar the work of others. Be extra careful to avoid using common notes from such collaborations.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offence. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science.

The consequences may be severe for a student if found guilty. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/study-environment-and-rules/disciplinary-matters/>